Petals in the Wind

By V.C. Andrews

INTRODUCTION

How young we were the day we escaped. How exuberantly alive we should have felt to be freed, at last, from such a grim, lonely and stifling place. How pitifully delighted we should have been to be riding on a bus that rumbled slowly southward. But if we felt joy, we didn't show it. After all, it took the death of Cory, Carrie's twin to give us the courage to escape. And now we sat, all three, pale, silent, staring out the windows, very frightened by all we saw.

Petals in the Wind by V.C. Andrews

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

CATHY: We were the youngest on the bus. Chris was seventeen years old and strikingly handsome. Curled up on my lap was my younger sister. She didn't look older than three, but she was eight years old and small, so pitifully small, and weak. In her large, shadowed blue eyes fingered more dark secrets and sufferings than a child her age should know. And me: I was fifteen and sat tense, ready to scream if one more bad thing happened.

CARRIE: Cathy, I don't feel so good. My stomach, it feels funny...."

CATHY: I was seized by fear. Her small face seemed unnaturally pale; her hair, once so bright and shining, hung in dull, lank strings. Her voice was merely a weak whisper. Violently Carrie jerked upright and began to choke and retch.

Carrie began to whimper and tremble. I felt her forehead and it was clammy, and now her face wasn't just pale, but white! I

prayed that just once God would have some mercy on us. While I hesitated with the squeamish desire to vomit myself, Carrie let go again. I couldn't believe she had anything left. I sagged against Chris while Carrie went limp in his arms and looked heartbreakingly near unconsciousness.

CHRIS: I think she's going into shock. Cathy, we've got to get Carrie to a doctor, and soon!"

CATHY: "Look here, driver," yelled the meanest man on the bus. "Get that sick kid to a hospital! Damned if I paid my good money to ride on a stinking bus!"

And thank God, the driver listened. Soon we were rolling along quiet, wide streets with trees that arched gracefully overhead. Really, they didn't put medical buildings on this kind of residential street. But just as I was beginning to get worried, the bus jerked to a sudden halt in front of a big white house perched on a low, gentle hill and surrounded by spacious lawns and flower beds.

Chris very gently, and with a great deal of tenderness, lifted Carrie in his arms. We walked up the long brick walk to the front veranda and there I hesitated. To the right a small sign read DR. PAUL SHEFFIELD: FOR PATIENTS ONLY. This was obviously a doctor who had offices in his own home. I scanned

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

the veranda to spy a man sleeping in a white wicker chair. Slowly we approached.

CHRIS: Are you Dr. Paul Sheffield?

CATHY: Carrie lay in his arms with her neck arched backwards, her eyes closed and her long golden hair waving in the soft, warm breezes. Reluctantly the doctor came awake.

DR. SHEFFIELD: Yes, I'm Dr. Sheffield.

CATHY: He rose to his feet and stepped closer to peer down into Carrie's small, white face. He parted her closed lids with forefinger and thumb.

DR. SHEFFIELD: How long has this child been unconscious?

CATHY: He then led us to the door for patients only. Full of a thousand anxieties, Chris and I backed up against a wall and watched as the doctor checked Carrie's blood pressure, her pulse, her temperature and listened to her heart, front and back. My clothes felt damp and miserable, and suddenly I remembered why. Quickly I turned to unzip and remove my filthy outer skirt.

DR. SHEFFIELD: Do you always wear more than one outfit on Sundays?

CATHY: Only on the Sundays I run away. Chris nudged me sharply, mutely signaling I was revealing too much.

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

DR. SHEFFIELD: Sooo, you three are running away. And just what are you running from?

CHRIS: It's a long story, Doctor, and right now all we want to hear about is Carrie.

DR. SHEFFIELD: So we'll talk about Carrie. I don't know who you are, or where you're from, or why you feel you have to run. But that little girl is very, very ill. I suggest you contact your parents immediately.

CATHY: Just the words to make me panic!

CHRIS: We're orphans. Now, tell us what you suspect is wrong with our sister, and what you can do to make her well again.

DR. SHEFFIELD: Hold up there young man. First you have to answer a few questions. First, what is your name?

CHRIS: I am Christopher, and this is my sister, Catherine, and Carrie is eight years old, whether or not you believe it!

DR. SHEFFIELD: Now look. Let's stop being suspicious of one another. If you really want to help your sister, you have to give me the truth, or else you're wasting my time and risking Carrie's life.

CATHY: We were so scared, so damned scared to speak the full truth -- for who would believe? We'd trusted those who were supposedly honorable before so how could we trust again?

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

DR. SHEFFIELD: All right, if it's that difficult, let me ask more questions. Tell me what all three of you ate last.

CHRIS: Our last meal was *breakfast* very early this morning. We all ate the same thing, hot dogs with everything, french fries dipped in catsup, and then chocolate milkshakes.

DR. SHEFFIELD: And all three of you ate exactly the very same things for *breakfast?* And only Carrie was nauseated? Is Carrie often nauseated?

CHRIS: Well...Carrie threw up twice last week.

CATHY: Oh, the evasive way Chris was telling about Carrie made me really furious! He would protect our mother even now, after all she'd done. Maybe it was my expression that betrayed Chris and made the doctor lean my way, as if he knew he'd hear a more complete story from me.

DR. SHEFFIELD: Look, you came to me for help, and I'm willing to do what I can, but you aren't giving me a fair chance if you don't give me all the facts. Already I know Carrie is malnourished and underdeveloped for her age. You are all pale, thin and weak looking. You sit there with gold and diamond watches, wearing rich clothes and shoddy sneakers, and tell me half-truths. So now I'm going to tell you a few *full truths!* I suspect your small sister is dangerously anemic. Her blood pressure is dangerously low. And there is some elusive factor I can't put my finger on.

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

So, tomorrow Carrie will be admitted to a hospital, whether or not you call your parents, and you can hock those wristwatches to pay for her life.

CATHY: Wait a minute! My brother isn't telling you everything! . . .and then I began to tell what must have seemed to the doctor an incredible tale. At first I could tell he thought I was lying, or at least exaggerating. Why was that when every day the newspapers told terrible tales of what loving, caring parents did to their children?

... after Daddy was in that fatal accident, Momma came and told us she was deeply in debt, and she had no way to earn a living for the five of us. She began writing letters to her parents in Virginia. She told us her parents lived in a fine, rich house called Foxworth Hall in Virginia and were fabulously wealthy, but because she had married her half-uncle she'd been disinherited. She didn't even give us time to say good-bye to our friends. That very evening we set off on a train headed for grandparents we never new and Foxworth Hall.

Our mother told us we'd have to hide away until she could win back his affections. Momma said one night only, or maybe two or three, then we could go downstairs and meet her father. He was dying of heart disease and never climbed the stairs so we were safe enough up there as long as we didn't make much

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

noise. The grandmother gave us the attic to play in. It was huge -- and dirty, and full of spiders, mice and insects. And that's where we played and tried to make the best of it. But soon enough we found out that our grandfather was never going to forgive our mother for marrying his half-brother and we were going to remain 'Devil's issue.' We'd have to live up there until he was dead!

We soon found out our grandmother hated us too! She gave us a long list of what we could do and what we couldn't do. We were never to look out of the front windows, or even open the heavy draperies to let in some light.

Another year came, and that summer Momma didn't even visit us at all! Then, in October she showed up again to tell us she'd married a second time and had spent the summer touring Europe on her honeymoon! In that one room, Doctor, we lived three years and four months and sixteen days.

DR. SHEFFIELD: [disbelieving pause] It's a strange story, Cathy, and really, quite hard to believe.

CATHY: I haven't finished. The grandfather did die, and he did write our mother into his will so she'd inherit his tremendous fortune -- but he added a codicil that said she could never have children. If it were ever proven she'd given birth to children by

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

her first husband, she'd have to forfeit everything she'd inherited and everything she'd bought with the money!

Now that mysterious, elusive factor you can't put your finger on -- the thing wrong with Carrie that makes her throw up, and us too sometimes. It's really very simple. You see, once our mother knew she could never claim us and keep the fortune, she decided to get rid of us. The grandmother began to add sugared doughnuts to the basket. We ate them eagerly enough, not knowing that they were coated with arsenic.

That's our full horrible, awful truth. And regardless of what you believe, will you help us? Help Carrie? Please?

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: V.C. Andrews
ISBN: 978-0671729417
Publisher: Pocket Books
Date (Month/Year): Nov 1990

AWARD

Utah State Finalist – DI - Female

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY